

Design And Access Statement

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Proposal: Change of Use of first floor from Use Class C3 (residential) to Use Class F2 (Local Community Uses)

Location: The Meeting House, 42 Brook Street, Hexthorpe, Doncaster, ZZ46 0BG

Introduction: This is an application for change of use of the first floor only at the Property from existing residential use (Use Class C3) to use as part of the existing community centre (Use Class F2). Some internal alterations are proposed to the first floor, effectively merging two of the existing units into meeting space and associated areas. No works are proposed to the third unit although it will not remain a self-contained flat but will comprise additional integrated space for the community use, possibly used for storage, small meetings and/or manager's accommodation from time to time. The overall single use will be within Use Class F2 for the entire property. No changes are proposed for the ground floor or car park (existing community use) or any of the external elevations, boundaries and areas. There will be no changes to the existing utility connections at the Property.

There will be no changes to the access to the site or internally within the Property. The first floor will remain accessed through the internal stairwell from the ground floor which can be accessed from both the front and rear entrances to the Property. The external fire escape at the rear of the Property will also remain and provide ongoing emergency escape for the first floor.

There is disabled step-free access across the whole of the ground floor which also has access to toilets. Given the very dated and outmoded nature of the structure (over 100 years old), it is not feasible to provide disabled access to the first floor, either in practical terms and/or on account of the overwhelmingly high cost compared to the likely occupier's budget and what the Property can support. Any such requirement would therefore restrict the ability to improve, or even use on an ongoing basis, the existing ground floor community centre.

History: The property was used from original construction in the early 20th century as a public house, known as The Rising Sun, with that use continuing until around <redacted_date>. Following the closure of the public house, the property was acquired by Hexthorpe Methodist Church and used as a drop-in centre and other community uses ("The Junction"). This was pursuant to a planning consent (01/4290/P) for "change of use from A3 use (Public House) to community advice/drop in centre" granted on <redacted_date>. Design and Access Statement Page 2 To support the ongoing running costs of that centre, some of the first floor was converted into flats pursuant to planning consent (02/<redacted_date>/P) for "change of use from first floor community drop-in centre to first floor self contained flat" which was granted on <redacted_date>. There are other planning consents relating to alley gates, notice boards, fire escapes and fascia signs but these are of no relevance to this application. The Junction closed in <redacted_date> and the property has recently been sold by the Methodist Church to Pentrose Homes Ltd, a locally based company. Negotiations have taken place between the new owner and a different community based group (The Sudanese Community in Doncaster CIC) who wish to occupy the Property but with the first floor included for additional meeting and community space rather than the existing residential use. This is, in effect, a reversal of consent 02/<redacted_date>/P back to the position under consent 01/4290/P. The proposed new occupier has been searching for a building to establish a centre for some time but with no suitable accommodation identified. This, therefore, a community demand led proposal. The Property was previously registered as an asset of community value but has recently been removed from that list. The Property is not a Listed building and is not situated within a Conservation Area.

Policies: The Proposals Map, forming part of the Doncaster Local Plan <redacted_date>-<redacted_date> (adopted <redacted_date>), identifies the Property as falling within the Doncaster Main Urban Area and a Residential Policy Area. Policy 10 (RPA) confirms that "the establishment or increase of non-residential uses of appropriate scale will be permitted provided they would not cause unacceptable loss of residential amenity through, for example, excessive traffic, noise, fumes, smells or unsightliness". The supporting text notes that other uses, including community facilities, can meet local needs in a sustainable way and contribute to the variety and attractiveness of residential areas. Given that there will be no external alterations to the Property and that the proposal is only for a slightly enlarged overall community space, there will be no loss of residential

amenity. Equally, there is sufficient on-site private car parking already in use for the Property together with a small public parking area opposite. In any event, many visitors and users will continue to be from the local community and easily walk to the property (many will not have access to private transport) whilst there is an excellent public bus service in the area. Design and Access Statement Page 3 Whilst the proposal would result in the loss of the residential space, the existing flats provide outmoded accommodation with small 1-bed units not purpose built, poor energy performance levels, poor acoustic insulation (especially on a busy road junction) and indirect and unattractive access via a shared staircase at the rear of the building. Two of the flats are in a very poor condition and would require significant expenditure (commercially unviable) to reinstate them in a condition fit for habitation. One of the flats has been largely vacant since conversion in <redacted_date>. Overall, there is therefore little loss to the overall usable residential stock in the area. Policy 51 (Protection of Education, Community and Leisure Facilities) confirms that "...land and buildings currently used or last used for education (including school playing fields), community and leisure facilities, will be retained or developed for such purposes. Development resulting in the loss of an existing education, community or leisure facility, or land allocated for such purpose, will be assessed on merit and only be permitted where: A) the buildings or land are no longer fit for the purpose which they were being used due to size, layout, design and condition and that no alternative community use can be found; B) there is no longer a need or demand for the facility; C) alternative provision can be made on another site to the same or higher standard in terms of quantity, quality and community benefit; or D) the current use will be retained and enhanced by the development of a small part of the site." The supporting text notes that "community facilities contribute to sustainable communities. They play an important part in ensuring a good quality of life by supporting the needs of residents and workers in the Borough. They can provide services that help foster social cohesion. Many are playing an increasingly important role to support Doncaster's growing and ageing population". The proposal for an extension of the community use onto the first floor fully aligns with this policy and the supporting text. No loss of community space is proposed and instead the extended area will support the existing important local ground floor community facility and enable a greater range of functions to take place at the same time. This could include community meetings, outreach projects, drop in advice and support, educational programmes and a possible continuation of meeting rooms for the City of Doncaster Communities Team (who have used the premises previously over many years and have informally expressed support for this proposal).

Conclusions: Our conclusions are as follows: 1. The proposal concerns the first floor only at the Property and would provide a much improved community centre and with the loss of very poor quality residential units which have added little to the local area since their provision in <redacted_date>; Design and Access Statement Page 4 2. There will be no reduction in access to the overall Property including existing entrances, stairs and disabled access to the ground floor. It is not feasible to provide disabled access to the first floor; 3. There is sufficient on-site private car parking already in use for the Property together with a small public parking area opposite. Many visitors will continue to be from the local community and easily walk to the property whilst there is an excellent public bus service to the area. 4. The proposal effectively reverses an earlier planning decision and is being demand driven by a local community organisation who cannot find similar suitable accommodation; and 5. The proposal is fully aligned with adopted planning policies. There will be no loss in residential amenity in the area and the extended community use will better support the needs of residents and workers in the City, i.e. continuing to help foster social cohesion.

PENTROSE HOMES LTD <redacted_date>